pointed another committee, under chief secretary Rajesh Aggarwal, to invite suggestions and objections and conduct hearings—though the report is not public yet.

A total of 59 castes are in the state's SC list. Despite a rise in reach, the Sangh parivar has struggled to shed its Brahminical image. With disruptions in the Dalit sphere like Bhima-Koregaon behind it, Sangh affiliates have countered with inroads into Hindu Dalit groups like the Matangs and Charmakars, who form the bulk of Hindu Dalits. New ring-fencing of categories, they say, will protect their interests.

This has a precedent in the state's 30 per cent OBC quota: 11 per cent within that is set aside for Vimukta Jati (VJ) and Nomadic Tribes (NTs); the latter spectrum is further subdivided into denotified tribes or VJ (3 per cent), NT B-category (2.5 per cent), C-category (Dhangars, 3.5 per cent) and D-category (Vanjaris, 2 per cent).

THE DALIT DILEMMA

12
Percentage of SCs in Maharashtra population

59
No. of SC castes; Buddhist Dalits are largest group, then Matangs, Charmakars

13
per cent quota for SCs in education and jobs in state



"MANY SC SECTIONS ARE BEING DEPRIVED OF QUOTA BENEFITS. THE SC CATEGORY MUST BE SPLIT INTO FOUR SUB-CATEGORIES"

VIKRAM GAIKWAD
Matang leader



"THIS (SUB-DIVISION) WILL DIVIDE SC CASTES RATHER THAN UNIFY THEM. INSTEAD OF BREAKING CASTE BARRIERS, IT WILL HARDEN THEM"

AMAR SABLE
Former BJP MP

- **Badar report sets off Dalit sub-quota debate**
- **Buddhist Dalits corner the benefits, allege Hindu Dalits**
- **One view is wait for census, get exact SC caste numbers before any action**

RESERVATIONS OVER IT

Such a prospect for Dalits splits even the Mahayuti into a spectrum of opinions. Some BJP leaders, like MLC Amit Gorkhe, seek sub-quotas; others, like former BJP Rajya Sabha MP Amar Sable and ex-minister and NCP MLA Rajkumar Badole, well, have reservations. Sable demands a "fact-finding committee" to prove uneven benefits. Badole questions the haste around the Badar panel. "The new Census will yield contemporary data on the economic, educational, and political progress made by various SC castes...why not first wait for its results," he asks.

Badole also puts his finger on the key political point: any quota within a quota would divide the sense of consolidation among Dalits, whom he calls a homogenous class insofar as having been equal victims of untouchability. "A Presidential order is needed to include a caste in the SC category. How can it be left to the discretion of states to go in for sub-categorisation?" he asks.

Opposition leaders like Dr Ambedkar's grandson Prakash and former Congress minister Nitin Raut, too, have slammed the move. Raut questions the empirical and technical basis of the exercise, and asks how political reservations would be split. Five Lok Sabha seats and 29 assembly seats in Maharashtra are reserved for SCs.

Vikram Gaikwad of the Matang Samaj Sangh, a face of the second largest Dalit group, insists quotas presently pass over "the deprived sections". Splitting them into four sub-categories will ensure all castes will benefit, instead of a select few, goes the line. The government says the process is on, though social justice minister Sanjay Shirsat admits the Badar report needs to be made public for the public to file their objections and suggestions.

Outside the policymaking sphere, the move promises to run into the main current of Dalit empowerment politics. Sociologist P.G. Jogdand, former dean, Faculty of Arts, University of Mumbai, says sub-categorisation is not in line with the constitutional scheme. "This is part of divide-and-rule politics," he alleges. Refuting the contention that Buddhist Dalits had "cornered" quota benefits, he says the community is simply more numerous and was also the first to take to education and hence enabled to avail the opportunities.

The counter is six decades old. In 1965, the B.N. Lokur committee had noted: "It has been in evidence for some time now that a lion's share [of quota benefits] is appropriated by numerically larger and politically well-organised communities. The smaller and more backward communities have tended to get lost, though more deserving of special aid." That was the logic behind the Supreme Court's August 2024 permission for state-level sub-quotas. ■